

ORACLE Charts Out JAVA'S Future

The US software maker provides a glimpse into the world of Java, Oracle software and hardware, and the future of these technologies.

May 10-11, Oracle JavaOne and Oracle Develop 2011, Hyderabad, India:

Before the launch of JavaOne at the Hyderabad International Convention Center, there was much anticipation about the keynote on Java strategy and directions. This was to be jointly given by Nandini Ramani, vice president, Java Client Development, and Param Singh, senior director, Product Development, Oracle. Many Java developers and user groups consider Oracle's stewardship of Java as unsatisfactory. When Oracle took over Sun Microsystems two years back, there were doubts about whether a follow-the-money enterprise like Oracle would ensure continued investment and innovation in Java technology. This was especially so because Sun had been unable to make money off Java and there were high chances that Oracle would relegate it to the background if business returns were not forthcoming.

Battling uncertainties

James Gosling, often called the 'Father of Java', also expressed mixed feelings about Oracle's ability to handle Java. He left the company in April 2010—just a few months after Oracle acquired Sun. During the Hadoop Summit 2010, Gosling said that he believed that on the server side, Oracle would "execute really well" but beyond that he was unsure how Java would fare.

Lack of a concrete roadmap, and uncertainty about the future of OpenJDK7 (a.k.a. Open Java Development Kit) and JDK7 were some of the issues that many wanted to see clarified by Oracle at Oracle JavaOne and Oracle Develop 2011. Organised for the first time in 1996, JavaOne is said to be the world's largest conference for Java developers. This was the first time that the conference was held in India.

Looking beyond the Sun-to-Oracle transition

Highlighting the developments on Java at Oracle, Ramani, who was a long-time Sun employee prior to Oracle's acquisition, said, "I can tell you the transition from Sun to Oracle has been very positive. Sun, of course, was a great place for Java, but we were a hardware company with software as a side focus. I was at Sun for 16 years, which really is a long time; yet having come to Oracle, I can tell you, it is very focused. Oracle is committed to making Java successful across the board and is strongly focused on growing the developer base and the rate of adoption."

"We are making some great progress. For instance, Java Community Process (JCP) is moving again; we are filing Java Specification Requests (JSRs). Versions 7 and 8 of the Java Development Kit, which have been four years in the making, are finally happening, and the releases are just around the corner. The other big development is on the client side, with Java FX (a software platform for creating and delivering rich Internet applications) enhancements, which will enable it to become the premier environment for rich client applications."

Singh added, "The focus and the commitment that Oracle has on Java is obvious. You can see the results for yourself by downloading the latest versions of JDK7 or seeing the work happening in Java FX. We are actually very excited to work with the community, ISVs, operators and OEMs, to not only learn more about their requirements but to work with them to modernise the platform and take it forward."

Java and the business side

Highlighting that the software maker has been quite disciplined about extracting money from its technologies, Ramani said, "Oracle is a business-focused company and Java is vital to its success. Oracle is making huge investments to ensure that Java thrives in various areas." She added, "Oracle itself has over 10,000 Java developers. All of our fusion middleware is written in Java. It's used in every major industry segment and has a presence in a wide range of devices, computers, and networks."

Sharing the latest developments and technologies related to Java, Ramani stated, "The company is making huge investments to ensure that Java thrives, which in different areas means different things. Take, for instance, Java Platform, Enterprise Edition (EE). It is on a path; it has had a cadence of execution. We have delivered JSRs and are filing the new EE7 JSR. So the investment in EE is guaranteed."

"Oracle has continued to invest in Toplink (an object-relational mapping (ORM) package for Java developers) and BEA Weblogic (a J2EE application server). Oracle didn't shut down any of these but enhanced them. So, you will see Glassfish (an open source application server project for the Java EE platform) and Weblogic together. Additionally, in Java Platform, Standard Edition (SE), JRockit (a proprietary Java virtual machine or JVM) was a contender for HotSpot JVM (a Java virtual machine for desktops